

Questions for Sidra במדבר

1. What need is there for HaShem to order the counting of the Bnei Yisroel? The All-Knowing Ribbono Shel Olam knows exactly how many there are in the Bnei Yisroel without actually counting them?
2. HaShem commands that the count of the Bnei Yisroel is to be obtained by each person to be counted giving a token and these token are then to be counted. But why this roundabout way of counting the people? Why not simply count them directly?
3. What was the silver half-Shekels that were collected for the counting of the people actually used for? What significance, do you think, can be seen in this?
4. Which of the Tribes was not included in the general count of the Bnei Yisroel and why, do you think, was this so?
5. Why was this Tribe singled out in this manner?
6. What were the duties of the three families of the Tribe of Levi?
7. What can be considered as unusual (mathematically speaking) about the totals of the counted Tribes of the Bnei Yisroel and how, do you think, this can be explained?
8. Looking at the Plan of the Camp, find an example of a good neighbour's influence upon the people who live near him.
9. Again looking at the Plan of the Camp, find an example of a bad neighbour's influence upon the people who live near him.
10. Looking at the Plan of the Camp, how much space was there between the Machaneh Shechinah and the Machaneh Levi'yoh and Machaneh Yisroel? Can you suggest a reason for this exact space?
11. Once again, looking at the Plan of the Camp, you will see that each of the blocks of three Tribes of Yisroel is given a number. What do these numbers signify and what happened to the number 2?

Questions for Haftarah במדבר

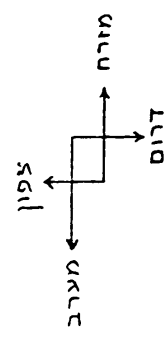
12. What is the connexion between the Sidra and this Haftarah?
13. What famous Pesukkim taken from this Haftarah are said by every grown man in his Davvening almost every single weekday?

SIDRA OF THE WEEK: במדבר

1. This week's Sidra is the first in the fourth *Sefer* of the Five Books of the Torah. It treats of the counting of the Jewish People (and thereby gives it its name "*Chumash haPekkuddim*" or "Numbers"); how we were encamped during our time in the Wilderness of Sinai on our way out from Egypt to Eretz Yisroel; the order in which we broke camp and travelled; some of the duties of the different houses of the Tribe of Levi; and the names of those in charge.
2. In the same way as a king newly enthroned wishes to get to know his subjects so too before HaShem came to dwell amongst us in the recently completed Sanctuary, HaShem commanded Mosheh to take a count of His People. By ordering the counting of the People of Israel — every man aged twenty years or more was to be included — HaShem showed that each man standing at the head of his household, prepared to place himself with his family within the ranks of HaShem's People, under the rule of HaShem and His Torah, is precious to Him.
3. The method of counting, too, is indicative of the importance of each person: The people were not to be counted directly, for this could imply that each is no more than a number. Instead, the Torah commands that each man gives a token (a half-Shekel) and these tokens are counted. The silver thus collected goes towards the upkeep of the Mishkan HaShem, and thus symbolizes how the Jewish People in its totality becomes the Abode of the Divine Presence.
4. The Tribe of Levi, however, is not included in the general count: as befits their special status as "the Legion of the King" they are counted separately. Similarly, whereas the Tribes of Israel were encamped round the Mishkan at a distance, the Levites, the guardians of the Sanctuary, encamped closer to the Mishkan. The position of each Tribe's camp is given in this week's Sidra (see PLAN below) and the procedure of breaking camp and travelling is also described.
5. As reward for their unbroken loyalty to Him, HaShem commands the Levites to be the assistants to the Kohanim instead of the firstborns of the Children of Israel, and their induction into their Divine Service and their various duties are described.

For the explanation of the Haftorah of Sidra במדבר please go to HAFTORAHs.

תמונה



NOT DRAWN TO SCALE

12 מיל = approximately 9 miles.

In the corners of the Camp:

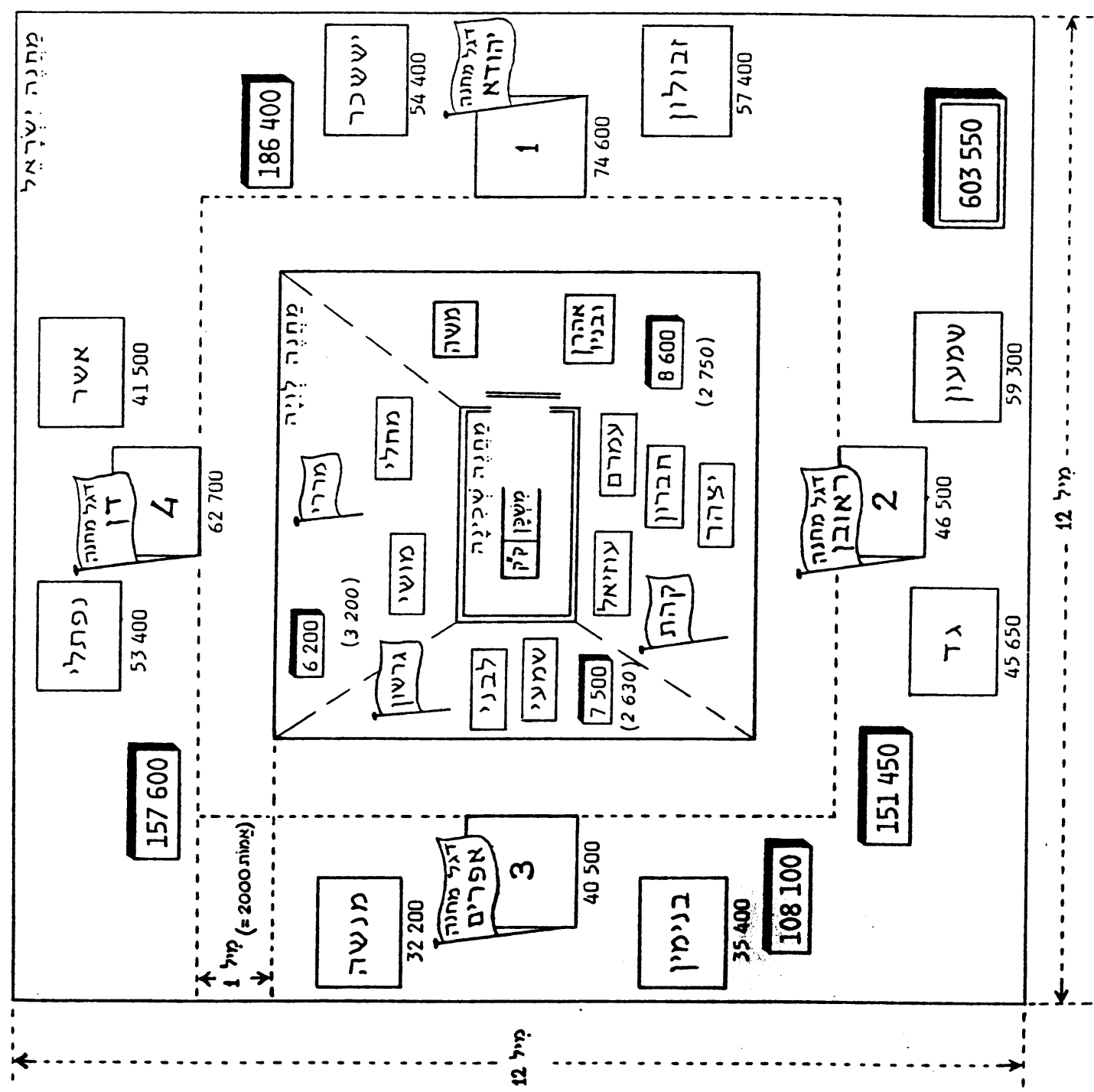
sheep, cattle, livestock, etc.

Levi'im: Numbers in boxes are of males aged between one month and fifty years; numbers in brackets are of males over thirty years of age. Totals: 22 000 and 8 580 respectively. [במדבר ג' לט: ד' מה']

The Mishkan with the whole of

מחנה לויה and מחנה שכינה travelled after ראוהבן and before אפרים and before אפרים

PLAN OF THE CAMP
OF THE ISRAELITES
IN THE WILDERNESS
(פרשת במדבר ופרשת נשא)



SIDRA OF THE WEEK : במדבר

וַיֵּסַע אֹהֶל מוֹעֵד מִחֶנֶּה הַלְוִיִּם בְּתוֹךְ הַמַּחֲנֹת כַּאֲשֶׁר יֶחֱנוּ בֵּין יִשְׁעוֹ ...

[במדבר, ב' : י"ז]

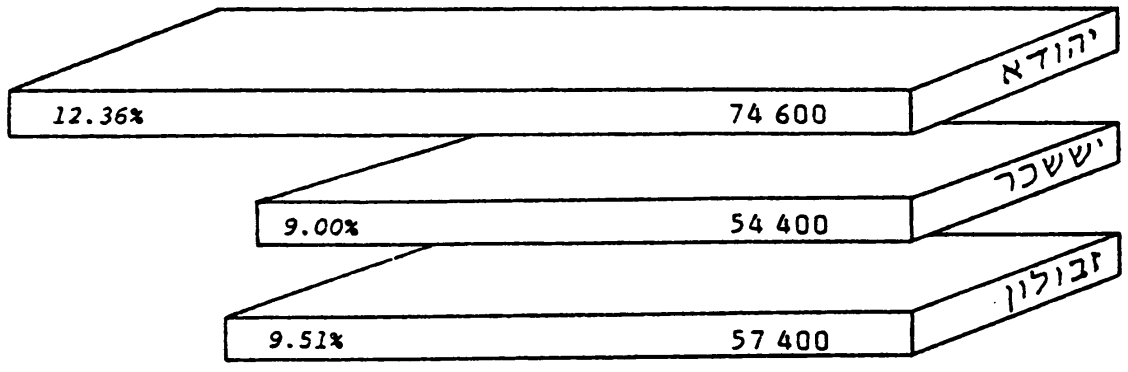
The Ohel Mo'ed [and] the Camp of the Levi'im travelled in the midst of the camps [of the Tribes] — as they encamped, so they travelled ...

[Bemidbor, 2 : 17]

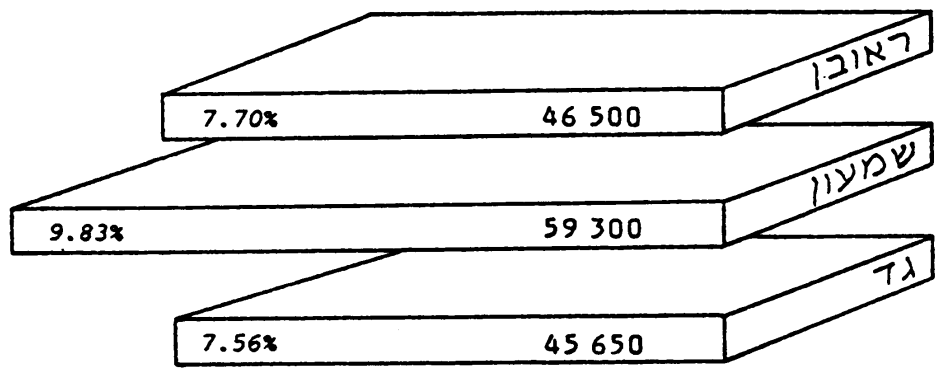
The first of the camps to travel was the camp comprising the Tribes of Yehuda, Yissochor and Zevulun, travelling under the flag of the leading Tribe, Yehuda. After them, the boards and the hangings and the curtains and the screens, etc., that all together formed the actual structure of the Mishkan, travelled. The great boards (which were the walls — there were 48 such boards) and the five pillars of the Mishkan (on which was hung the screen which formed the entrance of the Mishkan) and the columns of the Court around the Mishkan (there were 56 such columns) and the copper pegs and the ropes for the linen hangings which were hung from the columns and together formed the Court of the Mishkan, with the sockets for those boards, pillars and columns (there were some 160 sockets altogether — there were 96 silver sockets, each weighing one talent (approximately 68 kg) under the 48 boards of the Mishkan, two sockets for each board, and the other sockets, one for each pillar or column, were of copper) and the bolts for the walls of the Mishkan, etc., were transported by the Merorites of the Tribe of Levi. The coverings and the curtains and the entrance screen of the Mishkan and the entrance screen to the Court of the Mishkan, with their pegs and cords, etc., were transported by the Gershonites of the Tribe of Levi. The Gershonites and Merorites went ahead of the Kehosites and they would set up the Mishkan in the new location and so the Kehosites would find the Mishkan ready for the sacred furniture which they, the Kehostes, carried. After the Merorites and the Gershonites, the next camp to travel was the camp comprised of the Tribes of Reuven, Shimon and Gad, travelling under the flag of Reuven. After this second camp had moved off, the Kehosites travelled, as just said, carrying the Holy Ark and the other sacred furniture. This included the Table, the Menorah, the Golden Altar for the offerings of the incense, the Great Copper Altar, the Copper Wash Basin and its Copper Stand and also the Porochess, that is, the screen which separated between the Holy and the Holy of Holies. All this was not loaded on to any wagons but was carried on the shoulders of the Kehosites of the Tribe of Levi. The third camp to travel comprised the Tribes of Efrayyim, Menashe and Binyomin, travelling under the flag of Efrayyim, and they travelled immediately after the Kehosites. Finally, the camp of the Tribe of Dan, together with the Tribes of Osher and Naftoli, travelling under the flag of the Tribe of Dan, took up the rear. (Within this camp, therefore, there was a place for the claim and return of lost property.) Thus, figuratively as well as in fact, the *מַחֲנֶה שְׂכִינָה* and the *מַחֲנֶה לְוִיָּה* travelled within the camps of the Tribes of Israel — “as they encamped, so they travelled.”

מכיל

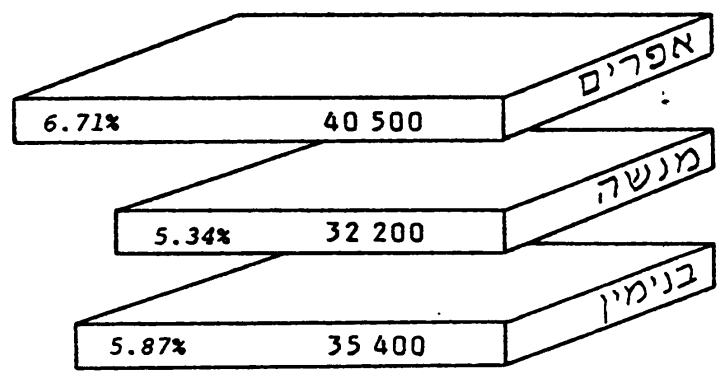
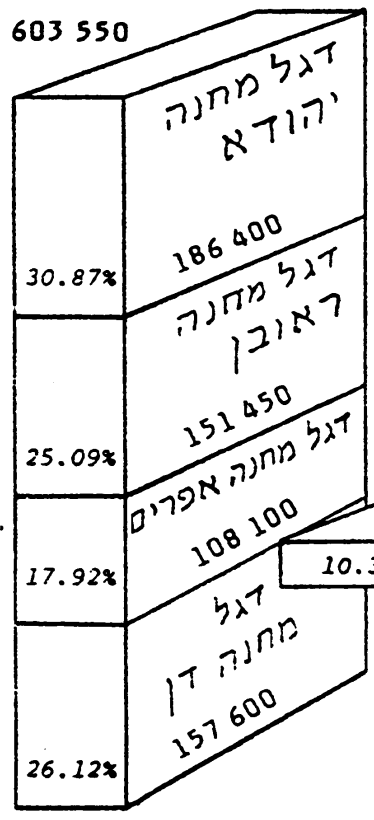
אלה הפקודים אשר פקד משה ואהרן ונשיאי ישראל
[במדבר א': מד]



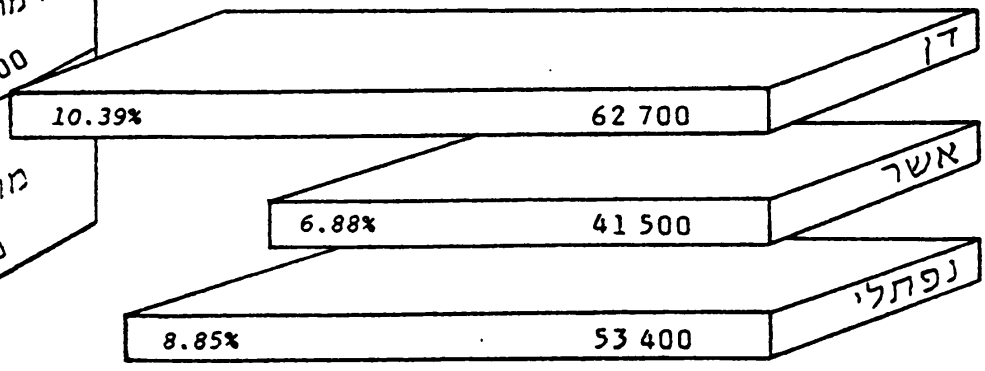
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HAFTORAH OF THE SIDRA : במדבר

*This week's Haftorah is taken from the Book of Hoshe'a,
one of the shorter Books of the Prophets which together make up "The Twelve,"
Chapter 2, from verse 1 till verse 22.*

IN THIS WEEK'S NOTES ON THE HAFTORAH,
AS IN MANY OF THESE "HAFTORAH OF THE WEEK" SHEETS,
CONSIDERABLE USE HAS BEEN MADE OF THE ADMIRABLE SERIES
"THE MIDRASH SAYS ON THE WEEKLY HAFTAROS"
BY RABBI MOSHE WEISSMAN AND PUBLISHED BY BENEI YAKOV PUBLICATIONS
FOR WHICH HELP GRATEFUL ACKNOWLEDGEMENT IS AGAIN HERE MADE.

1. The Novvi Hoshe'a was a contemporary of the prophets Yeshayohu, Amos and Micha and was a prophet for ninety years. He was a sad witness to the people of the Northern Kingdom being taken into exile by the king of Asshur as a result of their ignoring the repeated warnings of Hoshe'a to them (over a period of some forty years) to stop their idolatry. [See **HAFTORAH OF THE SIDRA VA-YIKRA** — ויקרא for some background explanation concerning the idolatry of ancient times.]
2. Our Chachommim tell us that when HaShem told Hoshe'a that He was angry with the Jewish People for their disloyalty to Him, Hoshe'a did not jump to their defence as quickly as HaShem would have wanted. On the contrary, Hoshe'a accepted HaShem's criticism of the Jewish People and even said that seeing that the whole world is HaShem's, He can go ahead and choose another nation. But that is not what HaShem wants to hear about His People and in response, HaShem tells Hoshe'a to imagine himself in a situation where he marries a woman and has children from her and then he is told to send her away with the children! Would he be willing to do so? Yet Hoshe'a had implied that HaShem should abandon His People. "See," says HaShem, "would you be willing to throw out your wife and children — even if there was some suspicion that she has been unfaithful and that the children are not even yours? Of course not! And yet you would suggest that I should take another people to be Mine? Never!"
3. Perhaps we can understand the response of Hoshe'a in a different way. Maybe Hoshe'a meant to say to HaShem: "The Jewish People," You say, "are disloyal to Me and have

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gone after other gods.” But **I** say, “Master of the Universe, the whole world is Yours! You can choose anyone You want to be Your People. Well, then, go ahead! See if You can find another people like them! You will not!” So, although the way he answered HaShem seemed to imply that HaShem should take another nation instead of the Jewish People, Hoshe’a is in fact saying that there is no-one who is as good as the Jewish People. Seen in this light, Hoshe’a is a champion of the Jewish People, even if his words to HaShem could have been more clearly in their defence.

4. The point has been made before in these explanation sheets that the different Nevi'im used very different kinds of delivery when they brought us their messages from HaShem. [See **HAFTORAH OF THE SIDRA VA-YAY-TSAY — וַיֵּצֵא**.] Indeed, even the ways in which HaShem communicates with His prophets differs greatly from Novvi to Novvi, perhaps reflecting the state of the relationship of the Jewish People and HaShem at the time or perhaps at different times in our history different methods of awakening the Nation are called for.
5. This Haftorah is a case in point. HaShem tells Hoshe’a to take as his wife a woman of bad repute. From this woman, known to have been unfaithful in the past, Hoshe’a is to have three children. Furthermore, Hoshe’a is told to give these children weird and unusual names for these names too are to serve as warnings to the Jewish People. The first, a son, he is to name “Yizre’el,” that is, “Wind-tossed,” implying how the Jewish People are about to be scattered among the Nations in exile because of their disloyalty to HaShem and His Torah. The second child, a daughter, Hoshe’a is to name “Lo-Ruchommoh” meaning, “No-Pity” because at that time that’s how HaShem feels towards the Jewish People. And the third child, another son, is to be called “Lo-Ammi,” “Not-My-People,” because that is how HaShem then considered them. Then he is to divorce the woman and throw out the children. As mentioned before, at this order, Hoshe’a protested that he couldn’t do it. “She is my wife and they are my children!” And HaShem rebukes him, saying, “And yet you would suggest that I abandon My Jewish People and take another people instead?! Never!”
6. There are differing opinions held by the classic commentaries about this particular Nevuah. Some do take it literally. But others say, “Heaven forbid that HaShem should ever command anyone to do this!” In the final analysis, whether it actually happened or not is not important: it is the message that counts. But besides this “acted-out prophecy,” the language and metaphors that Hoshe’a uses in his prophecies are particularly vivid and explicit and are intended to shock his listeners to cease their unfaithfulness and that the Jewish Nation should return to her loving “Husband.” That is, they should stop their consorting with strange gods and return to HaShem.
7. The connexion between the Sidra and the Haftorah is pretty straightforward. The Sidra is the first of the “*Chumash HaPekuddim*,” that is, the Chumash which is concerned

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with “*the counting*” of the Jewish People in the Wilderness and this Sidra indeed starts with HaShem’s command to Mosheh to take up the count of the Jewish People. And the first Possuk of the Haftorah is the memorable prophecy by Hoshe’a that “the number of the Jewish People will be as numerous as the sand on the seashore, which cannot be measured nor counted.”

8. But that’s more or less where the connexion ends. As described above, the prophecy of Hoshe’a continues with the message from HaShem exhorting the Jewish People to return to Him, but expressed in the surprisingly shocking language that was only too clear to the generation of the time of Hoshe’a. Hoshe’a tells them how they had strayed from the path of the Torah and therefore HaShem has decreed that they shall be scattered among the nations of the world as grain is winnowed in the wind and He shall have no pity on them.
9. The prophecy of Hoshe’a continues with the promise that in the great future to come the Jewish People will indeed return to HaShem, His anger will be transformed to love and those three signal-names of the children of Hoshe’a, too, will be transformed for the Jewish People. Greater and more spectacular than the scattering of the Jewish People will be the ingathering of their exiles; HaShem will again call them “My People” and He will indeed have pity on them. The Haftorah ends with the memorable promise of HaShem to His People: “I will take you in love to Me forever. I will take you in love to Me, for the sake of your righteousness and justice, in lovingkindness and in mercy. I will take you in love to Me because of your trust in Me and you will truly know HaShem.”